A Grammar
of
the Irish Language

by

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To

the Reverend

James Henthorn Todd, D.D.,

Fellow of Trinity College Dublin, etc.,

as an humble testimony

to the great value of his exertions

in preserving and illustrating

the monuments of the history and language of Ireland,

and as an acknowledgement

of the assistance derived from him

in the composition and arrangement of the following

pages,

THIS VOLUME

is inscribed

by his obedient, humble servant,

John O'Donovan

Preface

The following work was commenced in the year 1828, and has been since continued, with various interruptions. The Author, having in the interval visited every county in Ireland, has had opportunities of becoming acquainted with the provincial dialects of the language, as now spoken; and he has therefore noticed their more remarkable peculiarities, wherever they appeared to throw light on the Rules of Irish Grammar. He has also introduced copious examples from the remains of the ancient language still preserved in manuscript; a source of information peculiarly important, not only as preserving the original inflexions and forms of the language, but also because it has been hitherto almost entirely neglected by his predecessors, who, with the exception of Haliday, have all taken their examples from the modern vernacular Irish.

The Author has to return his thanks to the Provost and Senior Fellows of Trinity College, Dublin, for a donation of twenty-five pounds towards the expense of this work; also to the Founders of the College of St. Columba, who have adopted it as the Class-book of their more advanced students, and have borne the risk of its publication.

Amongst his private friends the Author has to return thanks to the Rev. Dr. Todd, of Trinity College, Dublin, at whose suggestion the work has been thrown into its present form, and who has read the proofs in passing through the Press; to Mr. E. Curry, who has supplied many examples from ancient manuscripts, and from the living language, as spoken in the west of Thomond; and to Mr. Hardiman, for the use of several valuable books, and many judicious suggestions as to the mode of arrangement and illustration adopted in the work. He is also indebted to Mr. Petrie for copies of some curious inscriptions from ancient Irish tombstones, and for the use of two woodcuts, representing the most ancient inscriptions in Irish characters known to exist, which were first published by Mr. Petrie in his valuable *Essay on the Round Towers of Ireland*.

J. O'D.

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Introduction

0.1 Of the Origin of Writing and Letters in Ireland

The question whether the pagan Irish had the use of alphabetic writing has often been discussed. Bollandus[a] and Innes[b] deny that the Irish were a lettered people before they received the Roman alphabet from the Christian missionaries; but the question has not been as yet handled on either side with a moderation likely to elicit the truth. O'Flaherty states that if Bollandus had consulted any Irishmne, well informed in the antiquities of Ireland, they could have produced for him the names of writers who had flourished in different ages before the mission of St. Patrick[c] And in this assertion he was perfectly borne out by the Bardic traditional history of pagan Ireland; for we read that letters were known not only to the Scotic or Milesian colony, but also to their predecessors, the Tuatha De Dananns[d]. Several poets of distinction are mentioned as of the Tuatha De Danann colony; and among the rest Ogma Mac Elathain, who is said to have invented one of the species of virgular characters called Ogham[e]; and Brigid, daughter of the Dagda, who was worshipped

[a] Acta SS. ad 17 Mart. tom. 2, in Vit. S. Part. sect. 4

[b] See the arguments of Innes, quoted hereafter TODO

[c] "Certe si Bollandus Hibernos antiquitatum suarum peritos consuleret, facile in medium proferrent, scriptorum nomenclaturam qui ante S. Patricii aposolatum diversis sæculis floruerunt" — *Ogyg.* Part iii. c. 30.

[d] No Ogham inscriptions have, however, as yet been found on any of the monuments ascribed by the Irish writers to the Tuatha De Dananns, excepting the cave in the mound at New Grange, which exhibits a few Ogham characters, and near them, a decided representation of a palm branch. To say that these are forgeries, and that they were engraved on the stone since the cave was opened in 1699, would be to beg the question. A great number of the stones within the chamber, as well as those in the gallery which leads to it, are carved with spiral, lozenge-shaped, and zig-zag lines, but these are evidently intended as ornaments, and not as phonetic characters or hieroglyphics.

[e] In the *Book of Ballymote* fol. 167, *b*, *b* commences a tract on the Ogham alphabets, in which the first invention of them is ascribed to Ogma, son of Elathan, above mentioned. This tract begins:
"Caide loc ⁊ aimṙiṅ 7 ṙeṅṙu 7 ꝑat aiṅic in Ogaim? Ní inn. Loc do Hiberniа inṙola quam noṙ Scoti habitamuṙ, i n-aimṙiṅ Briġe, mic Elatain, ṙiġ Eṙinn. Ṙeṅṙa do Ogma, mac Elatain, mic Delbaiṫ, deṙbṙaṫaiṅ do Briġ; áṙ Briġ, ⁊ Ogma, ⁊ Delbaeṫ iii mic Elatain. "
"What is the place and time, and person, and cause of [inventing] the Ogum? Not difficult.

by the poets of after ages as the goddess of poetry. Among the Scotic or Milesian colony, on their arrival in Ireland from Spain, we find Amergin, the brother of the leader of the colony, who is said to have been their poet, and chief Brehon or Judge; and there are on bardic record also the names of many poets and legislators, from this period down to Forchern, who is said to have composed the *Uraicecht*, or *Primer of the Bards*, in the first century. But the writers of the traditional history of Ireland go farther, and give a regular account of the period at which, and the persons by whom, the Irish letters were invented. They tell us that Fenius Farsaidh, King of Scythia, the great grandson of Japheth, son of Noah, set up a school of learning on the plain of Shenaar, which the *Book of Druim-Sneachta* places at Eothica[f], two hundred and forty-two years after the deluge, having tow assistants, Gaedhal, son of Eathor, and Iar, son of Nemha, otherwise called Cai Cainbhreatach: he there taught the Hebrew and the various languages which came into existence after the confusion of tongues.

After having presided over the school of Shenaar for twenty years, Fenius returned to his kingdom of Scythia, and there established schools, over which he appointed Gaedhal, the son of Eathor, as president. King Fenius then ordered Gaedhal to arrange and digest the Gaelic language into five dialects, the most polished of which was to be name *Bearla Feine*, after Fenius himself, while the language generally was to be named *Gaidhelg*, from Gaedhal. Fenius Farsaidh, we are told, reigned over Scythia for a period of twenty-two years after his return from the plain of Shenaar. He had two sons, Nenual and Niul; to the elder of whom he bequeathed his kingdom, but to the younger nothing but his learning. Niul continued for many years teaching in the public schools of Scythia, until the fame of his learning spread abroad into the neighbouring kingdoms, and at length Pharoah Cingcris [Cinchres], King of Egypt, invited him to his country to instruct the Egyptians in the various languages and sciences of which he was master. Niul set out for Egypt, and Pharaoh was so pleased with him, that he bestowed upon him the lands called Capaciront, or Capacir, situated near the Red Sea, and gave him his daughter Scota in marriage, from whom the Milesian Irish were afterwards called *Scoti*. After his marriage Niul[g] erected public schools at Capaciront, and

The place of it, *Hibernia Insola quam nos Scoti habitamus*; in the time of Bres, son of Elathan, King of Ireland. Its person [inventor], Ogma, son of Elathan, son of Delbhaeth, brother of Bres; for Bres, and Ogma, and Delbhaeth, were the three sons of Elathan."

[f]The *Book of Drum-Sneachta*, quoted by Keating.

[g]To this royal schoomaster of Egypt the chief Milesian families of Ireland trace their pedigrees, and are now about 118 generations removed from him, according to the genealogical lines preseerved in ancient and modern books and MSS. Thus, the present Viscount O'Neill is 129 generations removed from him; Sir Richard O'Donel 115; O'Conor Don 118; O'Dowda 116; the Marquis of Thomond 117; Justin Mac CArthy, of Carrignavar, 117; and O'Donovan 115. Now by allowing thirty years to each generation, it will appear, that Niul may have flourished about 3540 years ago, or 1695 years before Christ. This calculation will shew that the number of generations would sufficiently fill up the space of time; and that the line is not such a blundering forgery as might be supposed; but until we discover some real authority to prove by what means the Scotic or Gaelic race were able to

was there, instructing the Egyptians in the arts and sciences, at the very time that Moses took upon him the command of the children of Israel, 797 years after the deluge. At this time Niul had by Scota a son whom he named Gaedhal, in honour of his friend Gaedhal, the son Eathor, and from him, according to some of our historians, the Irish were called Gaoidhil, and their language *Gaoidheilg*. The descendants of this famous schoolmaster, after various adventures by sea and land, emigrating from Egypt to Crete; from Crete to Scythia; from Scythia to Gothia, or Getulia; from Gothia, or Getulia, to Spain; from Spain to Scythia; from Scythia to Egypt again; from Egypt to Thrace; from Thrace to Gothia; from Gothia to Spain[h]; finally arrived in Ireland under the conduct of two brothers, Heber and Heremon, sons of Milesius, and the twenty-first in descent from Gaedhal, son of Niul.

We are told further in the *Uraicecht*, preserved in the *Book of Lecan*[i], that the ancient Irish alphabet did not begin with the letters *a*, *b*, *c*, like the Latin, nor with *a*, *b*, *g*, like the Greek and Hebrew alphabets, but with the letters *b*, *l*, *f*, from which it received the name of *Bobel-loth*, or with *b*, *l*, *n*, from which it received the appelation of *Beth-luis-nion*. Each of the letters of the *Bobel-loth* alphabet took its name from one of the masters who taught at the great schools under Fenius Farsaidh, and in the *Beth-luis-nion* alphabet each letter was named after some tree, for what reason we know not[j].

The names and order of the letters in the *Bobel-loth* alphabet are as follows:

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preserve the names of all their ancestors, from the time of Moses to the first century, we must regard the previous line of pedigree thence to Niul and fenius, as a forgery of the Christian bards. Certain it is that at the present day oral tradition does not preserve the names of ancestors among the modern Irish, with any certainty, beyond the sixth generation. The author has tested this fact in every part of Ireland.

[h] Lhwyd, in one of his letters to Mr. Rowland, the author *Mona Antiqua*, expresses himself as follows on this subject: "Indeed it seems to me that the Irish have, in a great measure, kept up two languages, the ancient British, and old Spanish; which a colony of them brought from Spain. For notwithstanding their histories (as those of the origin of other nations) be involved in fabulous accounts, yet that there came a Spanish colony into Ireland is very manifest, from a comparison of the Irish tongue partly with the modern Spanish, but especially with the Cantabrian or Basque; and this should engage us to have something of more regard that we usually have to such fabulous histories." Sir William Betham, who has laboured more strenuously than even any of the native Irish writers of our times, to support the truth of the pagan history of Ireland, has attempted to prove, in his Etruria Celtica, "that the Milesian invaders of Ireland were those Phœnician colonists, who, with their brethren of Britain, after the destruction of the Phœnician cities and power, became independent, and carried on trade with their neighbours of the Continent, and after many ages were found by the Romans under Cæsar in Gaul and Britain; that the Phœnician Celts, on their first invasion of the British Islands and Gaul, were a *literate people*, possessing alphabetic writing and the elements of learning, and that the Irisih is but a modification of the old *Cadmean Phœnician alphabet*, in like manner as are the Etruscan, Greek, and Roman."—*Etruria Celtica*, vol. i. p. 10.

[i] Fol. 158 *a*, and 169 *a*. *Ogygia*, p. 235. There is a still more ancient copy of the *Uraicecht* in a MS. in the British Museum.

[j] Whoever wishes to read a long dissertation on this subject, a singular specimen of ingenious trifling, may consult Davies' *Celtic Researches*.

b	Bobel.	n	Nabgadon.
l	Loth.	h	Hiruath or Uria.
f	Foronn.	d	Davith.
s	Saliath.	t	Talcmon.
c	Cai.	q	Qualep.
m	Mareth.	g	Gath.
ng	Ngoimer.	st	Stru.
r	Ruben.	eu	Iachim or Iumelchus.
a	Achab.	oi	Ordinos.
o	Ose.	ui	Judæmos.
u	Uriath.	io	Jodonius.
i	Etrocuis or Esu.	ao	Aifrin.

The *Beth-luis-nion* alphabet is similarly arranged, but the names of the letters are taken from trees or shrubs, as follows:

b	beıch, the birch.	p	peċpoc, unknown.
l	luıſ, the mountain ash.	ſt or z	ſtꞇaıꞇ, the sloe tree.
ꞇ	ꞇeann, the alder.	ꞇ	ꞇuıſ, the elder.
ſ	ſaıl, the willow.	a	aılm, the fir tree.
n	nıon, the ash.	o	onn, furze.
h	huaċ, the hawthorn.	u	uꞇ, heath.
ꝺ	ꝺuıꞇ, the oak.	e	eaȯaȯ, the aspen.
t	tınne, unknown.	ı	ıȯaȯ, the yew.
c	coll, hazel.	ea	eaḃaȯ, the aspen.
ꝗ	ꝗueıꞇt, the apple tree.	oı	oıꞇ, the spindle tree.
m	muın, the vine.	uı	uılleann, woodbine.
ꞡ	ꞡoꞇt, ivy.	ıo	ıꞇın, gooseberry.
ng	ngeꝺal, the reed.	ea	amhanchol.—unknown[k].

On this simple story, handed down by the Irish bards, O'Flaherty remarks: "What if I should assert that our Fenius was that Phoenix who invented those ancient Greek characters which the Latins speak of. The Irish letters are not very unlike the Latin; the names of Phoenix and Fenisius, Phoenius, are not very different, and the invention supports it; the time and place in matters of such antiquity are very often confounded. Besides I have the authority of the above cited poet, Forchern, in favour of my conjecture, in whom we read: 'The book of Forchern begins. The place of the book [i.e. the place where it was written or published] was Emania. The time, when Conquovar, the son of Nessa, ruled Ulster. The person [i.e. the author of the book] was Forchern, the philosopher. Fenius Farsaidh composed the first alphabets of the Hebrews, the Greeks, the Latins, and also the Beth-lius-nin [i.e. the Irish alphabet], and Oghum[l].'"

[k] O'Flaherty acknowledges that he did not know the meaning of this name; but the Rev. Paul O'Brien, to whose etymological vision nothing presented the slightest difficulty, makes it aṁṛachol (Grammar, p. 210) which he forces to signify *witch* hazle, being derived, according to him from aṁṛa, vision [although the first portion of the word is aṁan, not aṁṛa] and col, hazle.

[k] "Quid si dicerem Fenisium nostrum istum fuisse Phœnicem literarum auctorem, qui Græcas eas vetustas depingeret, quas Latini referunt? a Latinis Hibernicæ non omnino abhorrent; Phœnicis, et Fenisii, vel Phœnii nomen non abludit, et inventio suffragatur; tempus et patria in hujusmodi antiquioribus sæpissimè confunduntur. Præterea conjecturæ meæ non deest authoritas supra laudati Forcherni poetæ, apud quem sic habetur. *Incipit liber Forcherni. Locus libri* [locus quo in lucem editus] *Emania* [Ultoniæregia]. *Tempus, Conquavaro filio Nessæ*;

These statements of O'Flaherty were sufficient to satisfy the mere Irish scholars of his day, but not so a Scotch writer, who flourished soon after, namely, Thomas Innes, M. A., a Roman Catholic priest, of acute mind and true learning. In his "*Critical Essay on the ancient Inhabitants of the northern Parts of Britain or Scotland*", London, 1729, he thus examines O'Flaherty's arguments in proof of the use of letters among the pagan Irish:

"We come now to examine the proofs that *Flaherty* brings, of the ancient use of letters among the *Irish*, before they received Christianity. The first is, that they have or had many books, poems, and histories, written in their *Pagan* ancestors' times. But all that is nothing but to beg the question, and to suppose what is under debate, till these books, or some of them, be published to the world, with fair literal translations, and documents to prove their authority and age, and to shew how, and where they have been preserved during so many ages

"2º. Flaherty, for a proof that the *Irish* had not the use of letters from the *Latins*, and by consequence that their letters were much ancienter than the preaching of the Gospel among them, and peculiar to the *Irish*, tells us, that their letters differed from those of the *Latins*, and all others in name, order, character, number, and pronunciation and force: to shew this, he gives from the Book of *Lecan* (an *Irish* MS. about three hundred years old) the copy of the *Latin* alphabet, inverted and digested in a new arbitrary order, with the names of trees attributed to each letter, beginning with the three letters b, l, n; and from thence called *Beth-luis-nion*. And this he pretends was the ancient *Irish* alphabet, before they had communication with the *Latins* and *Romans*.

"But when *Flaherty* sets about to prove the antiquity of this *Beth-luis-nion*, he brings

sc. Ultoniam moderante. *Persona* [author libri] *Forchernus philosophus* [fileadh], *Fenius* [Fenisius] *Farsaidh alphabeta prima Hebræorum, Græcorum, Latinorum, et Bethluisnin* [alphabetum Scoticum] *an Oghuim composuit*."—*Ogyg.* Part iii. c. 30, p. 221.

In the same chapter, O'Flaherty, after enumerating many of the poets, legislators, and other *literati* of pagan Ireland, says exultingly (p. 219) "Postremo Dualdus Firbissius patriæanti-quitatum professor hereditarius ex Majorum monumentis literis datis refert 180 Druidum, seu Magorum disciplinætractatus S. Patricci tempore igni damnatos." This assertion is very bold indeed, but no reference to it is found in any of the old *Lives of St. Patrick* published by Colgan, or in the *Book of Armagh*, and it is to be feared, that O'Flaherty has mistaken the meaning of the words of Mac Firbis, who generally wrote in the old Irish style, with which O'Flaherty had but a tolerable acquaintance. And he adds, that the same Duald Firbis wrote him an account of his being in possession of some of the *taibhle fileadh* or poet's tablets, made of the birch tree. "Scoticis literis quinque accidunt, in quorum singulis ab aliarum gentium literis discrepant; nimirum, Nomen, Ordo, Numerus, Character, et Potestas. Et quia *imperiti literarum in chartâ, aliave ulla materia ad memoriam pingendarum* harum rerum ignarus incautè effutiit Bolandus, de materiâ aliquid præfabor. Ea ante pergamenæusum tabulæerant e betulla arbore complanatæ, quas *Oraiun* et *Taibhle Fileadh*. i. Tabulas Philosophicas dicebant. Ex his aliquas inter antiquitatum monumenta apud se superfuisse, ut et diversas characterum formulas, quas ter quinquagenas a Fenisii usque ætate numero, et Craobh Ogham .i. virgeos characteres nomine recenset, non ita pridem ad me scripsit Dualdus Firbissius rei antiquariæ Hibernorum unicum dum vixit, columen, et extinctus, detrimentum."—*Ogygia*, p. 233.

for proofs stories more incredible than the facts themselves, which he intends to prove by them. *Flaherty* tells us then the story we made mention of already from *Keating* and *Toland*: that the first author of this alphabet was *Fenius-Farsaidh, who composed*, says *Flaherty, the alphabets* of the Hebrews, Greeks, and Latins; the Beth-luis-nion *and the* Ogum. This *Fenius Farsaidh* (as we said before) was, according to the *Irish Seanachies*, great grand-child to *Jafeth*, son to *Noah*, and lived in Noah's own time, about one hundred years after the deluge. For this piece of antiquity, *Flaherty* quotes one *Forcherne*, an *Irish* poet, who, as a late Irish writer informs us, lived one hundred years before the incarnation. Now, not to ask how this poet *Forcherne*, or Feirtcheirne, as old as he is placed, knew so distinctly things past, above two thousand years before the time in which he is classed, it may at least be enquired, by what spirit of prophecy this *Fenius Farsaidh* composed the Greek alphabets so long before *Cecrops* and *Cadmus*, and that of the *Romans*, some 1700 years before the *Romans* were a people. And will the authority of *Lecan*, a MS. of about three hundred years, convince the learned of so rare a discovery, as that of an *Irish* writer one hundred years before the birth of Christ?

" But to let that paradox pass, there needs no great skill of the *Irish* language, to shew that the *Beth-luis-nion* is nothing else but an invention of some of the *Irish Seanachies*; who, since they received the use of letters, have put the Latin alphabet into a new arbitrary order, and assigned to each letter a name of some tree; and that this was not the genuine alphabet of the Irish in ancient times, or peculiar to them, but a bare inversion of the *Latin* alphabet.

"For 1°. The genuine *Irish* alphabet consists only of eighteen letters; for so many only they make use of in that tongue, viz. A, B, C, D, E, F, G, H, I, L, M, N, O, P, R, S, T, U; whereas in *Flaherty's Beth-luis-nion* there are twenty-six letters, that is, eight supernumerary, viz. Q, X, Y, Z, OI, IO, NG, and EA: of these eight there are four which are never used in the genuine *Irish*, viz. Q, X, Y, Z; at least in such Irish books or MSS. as I could hitherto ever meet with, or hear of: but they are in use in the *Latin* tongue, and with the other eighteen letters make up the *Latin* alphabet: which therefore the *Irish* bard must have had before him when he invented the *Beth-luis-nion*. As to the syllables OI, IO, EA, and double letter NG, which are the other four letters in the BETH-LUIS-NION, they have no one proper character in the Irish, distinct from the common alphabet, but are expressed by two of the usual letters of it; and nothing but meer fancy could have placed them in this new alphabet as distinct letters from the other eighteen. So, I think, it is plain that this *Beth-luis-nion* was neither the genuine Irish alphabet, nor was in use among them till after the times of Christianity, when they received the use of the Latin letters, whereof this is but a bare transposition.

"As to the names of trees attributed to each letter, it seems visibly the work of meer fancy, without any reason or motive, there being no resemblance in the character of these letters to these trees, from whence this bard hath named them: whereas in the languages where the names of the letters are significative, as generally those of the *Hebrew*, the thing meant by these letters hath often some resemblance to the figure of the letter. And as for the term *Feadha*, *Woods*, which they gave to this alphabet, it was natural to call by the name

of a forest or wood an alphabet whereof each letter was metamorphosed into a tree.

"Another proof which the *Irish* modern writers bring for the antiquity of their letters, is from the form of their characters, as being peculiar to the *Irish*, and *not agreeing with the* Greek *or* Latin *characters, or perhaps any other now in the world*. But such arguments as these are only fit to impose upon those that never saw any *Latin* books or characters, but in vulgar print; and never had occasion to see any MS. but *Irish* : for if they had seen any ancient Latin MSS. or characters, they would have found, in the first place, by perusing those of the sixth, seventh, eighth, and following ages, down to the time of printing, as great differences betwixt the figures of letters, and form of the writing in MSS. of all countries, and the common print, as betwixt the usual characters in printed books, and those of the *Irish*; and yet originally all of them derived from the ancient *Roman* or *Latin* characters or letters.

"In the second place, the inspection of old *Latin* MSS. or charters will furnish new proofs to demonstrate, that the *Irish* had their letters originally from the *Latins,* or those that used the *Latin* characters; for all the characters of the *Irish* letters (without excepting the Saxon Y, G, P, Y, which seem more extraordinary to vulgar readers) are generally to be met with in the same form in ancient MSS. and charters, not only of *Britain*, but none of them but are in MSS. of other foreign countries[m], who had nothing to do with Ireland. And in many countries, where no body doubts they had the first use of letters from the *Latins*, the characters of old MSS. differ much more from the vulgar printed characters of the *Latin* than the *Irish* do. Such are the *Merovingian* and *Longobardick* characters: for a proof of this I refer the reader to schemes of characters, and of old writ, which he will find in the learned *F. Mabillon's* book, *De Re Diplomatica*, in case he have not the opportunity to inspect *Latin* MSS. where he will generally find, even in MSS. of the twelfth, thirteenth, and fourteenth ages, much the same characters, or forms of letters, that are made use of in the Irish tongue; and little or no difference, but in the forms of abbreviations: for which, not only the people of different languages, but every different writer, may invent such characters, or forms of contractions, as he fancies will most abridge.

"The same thing may be said as to the notes for writing secrets, called by the *Irish Ogum*; of which Waræus says he had some copies; and one *Donald Forbis* mentions others: for no body doubts but the *Irish* had their notes or cyphers for writing short-hand, and keeping

[m] Mr. Mac Elligott, in his *Observations on the Gaelic Language*, published in the Transactions of the Gaelic Society of Dublin, says: "Let any one look into Astle, on the Origin and Progress of Alphabetic writing, the Spectacle de la Nature, and the early printed Classics, and he will be convinced that the small alphabet used in early ages all through Europe, was borrowed from the Irish." p. 38. It is very true that the people who were converted to Christianity by the Irish missionaries in the seventh and eight centuries first obtained their letters from those missionaries; but it must be confessed that the oldest inscriptions found in Ireland (excepting the Ogham), are in the Roman alphabet of the fifth century, and it is well known that this, more or less modified, prevailed all over Europe till the introduction of the Gothic style of writing.

their secrets; especially the *Druids*, for preserving from the knowledge of Christians the secret of their profane mysteries, made use, no doubt, of secret characters or letters, from the time that once the use of letters was introduced in *Ireland*. All other nations, and every private man, may have the same, for keeping secrets, and those entirely different from their usual letters: such among the *Romans* were the *Notæ Tironis*, whereof a specimen may be seen in *F. Mabillon's* diplomaticks. Trithemius also hath written a book on the subject, De Steganographia: so I do not well conceive for what this serves towards proving the antiquity of the *Irish* letters; or that they were not originally the same as the *Roman* or *Latin* character. Since *Waræus*, who is brought in to prove that the Irish had such characters, tells us, that the *Ogum* did not contain the Irish vulgar character, but a hidden way of writing for preserving their secrets.

"And thus far as to the arguments brought by *Flaherty* and other modern *Irish* writers, against the opinion of the learned *Bollandus*, concerning the ancient use of letters in *Ireland*; with which subject, tho' *Flaherty* fills up about thirty pages of his *Ogygia*; yet the far greatest part is spent in useless flourishes on the origin of letters in general, and on the use and new order of the *Irish* new invention of *Beth-luis-nion*, there being little in his book, besides what we have mentioned, that looks like proofs of their having had the use of letters before Christianity, unless we call proofs citations of legends of St. *Patrick's* life, written long after his time.

"After all, I do not pretend that no private person among the *Irish* had the use of letters before the coming in of St. *Patrick*, and the preaching of the Gospel to them: for it may have very well happened, that some of the *Irish,* before that time, passing over to *Britain,* or other parts of the Roman empire, where the use of letters was common, might have learned to read and write. It might also have happened that the *Druids*, who were the magicians of these times, might have had certain hieroglyphick characters to express their diabolical mysteries; and that the remains of those are what *Toland* and others make such a noise about. But if the *Irish* had any distinct character or form of alphabetical letters different from those which we have above mentioned, and which were introduced to *Ireland* by St. *Patrick* how comes it that all this time, especially within these last fifty or sixty years, that the matter hath been agitated, and the dispute warm about it, none of them have ever published any specimen of these peculiar *Irish* letters, or at least an alphabet of them: such as *F. Mabillon* hath given of all ancient forms of letters, and Dr. *Hickes* more particularly of the *Runick*, and other northern characters?" vol. ii. pp. 444-452.

Not long after Innes, we find Dr. O'Brien reject the Milesian story as utterly unsupported by true history. In his strictures on the author of the *Remains of Japhet*, he writes as follows in the Preface to his Irish Dictionary: "As for this learned writer's making the Irish language a dialect of the Scythian, formed, as he says, upon the authority of the Irish bards, at the famous school on the plains of Shinar, or Senaar, by a king of Scythia, called Feniusa Farsa, son of Baath, who is pretended to be a son of Magog, I do not conceive how he can reconcile this opinion of the Irish being a dialect of the Scythian or Magogian language, with

that circumstance he mentions, p. 119, 'that it is called Gaoidhealg, from its first professor at the above school, by name Gadel, a Gomerian', and that the language he then spoke and taught as an usher of that school under that royal schoolmaster Feniusa Farsa, grandson of Magog, *is the langauge of the native Irish to this day*; a very venerable antiquity, I must confess. But at the same time I cannot but regret that this worthy gentleman, who appears but too well inclined to favour the antiquities of Ireland and Britain, did not consider that nothing could be of greater prejudice or discredit to them than asserting those fabulous genealogies, and the stories of the travels of the supposed leaders and chiefs of their ancient colonies, such as have been rejected with just contempt by all learned nations, first invented in Ireland by bards and romancers, after they came to some knowledge both of the sacred writings and profane histories; and in Britain by Nennius and Jeffry of Monmouth".

And again, in his remarks on the letter A. "We should not, in the mean time, forget that it is to this change made in the words *Gaill* and *Galic*, doubtless by our heathenish bards who inserted the letter *d*, that we owe the important discovery necessarily reserved to their successors who embraced Christianity, of those illustrious personages *Gadel* and *Gadelus*; the former an usher under that royal schoolmaster *Pheniusa Farsa*, king of Scythia, in his famous school on the plain of *Sennaar*, where this *Gadel* invented the Irish alphabet and the Gadelian language, so called, as it is pretended, from his name; and the latter a grandson of that king by his son *Niul*, married to *Scota*, daughter of Pharaoh *Cingris*, as our bards call him, instead of *Cinchres*, king of Egypt, under whose reign, they tell us, *Moses* and our *Gadelus* were contemporaries and great friends: and from this *Gadelus* our learned bards gravely assure us that the Irish derive their name of *Gadelians* who, they tell us, were also called *Scots*, from his wife the Ægyptian princess *Scota*. This discovery, I have said, was necessarily reserved to our Christian bards, as their heathenish predecessors most certainly could have no notion of the plain of Sennaar, of Pharaoh, or of Moses; objects not to be known but from the Holy Scriptures, or some writings derived from them, such as those of Josephus, Philo, &c. never known to the Irish bards before their Christianity."

Charles O'Conor, of Belanagar, also, though in his youth he had believed the pagan traditions with the same facility and enthusiasm as O' Flaherty, yet in his maturer years, gave up all hope of being able to convince the learned of the truth of the pagan history of Ireland, as handed down by the bards. On this subject he writes as follows, in his "Dissertation on the Origin and Antiquities of the ancient Scots of Ireland and Britain", prefixed to O'Flaherty's "Ogygia Vindicated", which he edited in the year 1775.

"Our earliest accounts of *Ireland* have been handed down to us by the bards, a race of men well qualified for working on the barren ground of broken traditions. Poetic invention gave existence to facts which had none in nature, and an origin which included some genuine truths, has been obscured by forged adventures on sea and land. A succession of monarchs has been framed, many of whom never reigned, and the line of genealogy has been opened, to make room for redundancies, without which the succession of so many monarchs could not be admitted by the most ductile credulity.

"Thus it fared in the infancy of things in *Ireland*, as well as in every other European country; and in all, we will find that the introduction of letters, far from limiting, has, in fact, enlarged (for a considerable time) the sphere of the ostentatious and marvellous. The registering of facts under the direction of nature and truth, has been the work of ages advanced in civilization. To these we will hasten; and that we may give no line to a fugitive hypothesis, or the fanciful excursions of ingenious idleness, we will not attempt to pass any of our most ancient traditions on our readers, but such as may be supported by parallel documents of foreign antiquaries, who held no correspondence with the natives of this island[n]."

He does not, however, go so far as to give up all claims of the pagan Irish to the use of letters: far from it; he argues that the ancestors of the Scoti must have had communications with the Phoenician colonies in Spain, from whom they must have borrowed their seventeen letters "so different in their powers, names and arrangement from those of the *Greeks* and *Romans*." He then writes as follows.

"This people, it is certain, know so little of *Greek* or *Roman* learning, that it was only in the fifth century they have learned the use of the *Roman* alphabet from the *Christian* missionaries. It was then, or soon after, that they laid aside their own uncouth and virgular characters, their *Beth-luis-nion*, and the *Ogum*; the form heretofore used, and since preserved by the antiquaries, either from vanity, or the more rational motives of preserving an ancient fact worthy of being recorded. The old manner of writing was indeed useless to the public, after a better and more elegant form was introduced; but yet the retention of the *Ogum* has had its use in latter times, by convincing us that the heathen Irish had the means of conveying their thoughts in cyphers, and consequently of recording memorable events, for the information and instruction of posterity. —Their jurisprudence, partly still preserved, the succession of their monarchs, their accurate chronology, and their genealogies, transmitted with great care from the first to the fifth century, are incontestible proofs of this truth. An earlier or more creditable era of cultivation than that, which began with the monarch *Feradach the Just* (a hundred years after the birth of *Christ*,) no nation in Europe can boast[o]."

Dr. Ledwich, however, argues that the Irish Ogums were secret alphabets invented in the middle ages, like the Runic inscriptions of the northern nations. He says:

"Verelius, Wormius, with many existing monuments prove, that the Northerns writ their runes in every possible form; in circles, in angles, from right to left, and vice versa. Wormius enumerates twelve different ways of making runic inscriptions. The German Buchstab or runes were drawn sometimes in horizontal, and sometimes in perpendicular lines. Here we have, if not the original of our Ogum Craobh, a practice exactly similar. In a word, these wonderful Irish Ogums were nothing, as we see, but a stenographic, or steganographic contrivance, common to the semibarbarians of Europe in the middle ages,

[n] pp. xxvii, xxviii

[o] pp. xxxviii, xxxix

and very probably derived from the Romans[p]."

The pagan antiquity of the Irish Oghams cannot be now established, to the satisfaction of the learned, except by existing monuments. It must be first proved that the monuments are undoubtedly pagan, and secondly, that the inscriptions are contemporaneous with such monuments, and not fabrications of after ages. The only monument with an Ogham inscription yet discovered, which exhibits all the apparent features of a pagan monument, is an artificial cave near the castle of Dunloe, in the county of Kerry. This interesting remain of ancient Ireland was discovered in 1838, by the workmen of Daniel Mahony, Esq., of Dunloe Castle. In constructing a sunk fence in one of the fields of the demesne, they broke into a subterranean chamber, of a curved form, which proved to be the termination of a gallery. The sides of the cave are constructed of rude stones, without any kind of cement, and the roof is formed of long stones, laid horizontally; an upright stone pillar extends from the centre of the floor of the cave to the roof, and is evidently designed to support it. This pillar stone is inscribed with Ogham characters, as are four of those which form the roof, in such a manner as to impress the conviction that they had been inscribed before they were placed in their present positions. In the passage were found several human skulls and bones, which clearly indicated the sepulchral character of the monument, and which Mr. Mahony removed to Dunloe Castle, in order to preserve them.

The Author of this Grammar examined this cave in the year 1841, and can testify that the inscriptions are not fabrications; but whether the monument be pagan or early Christian, he will not take upon him to decide. Ogham inscriptions are constantly referred to in the oldest Irish historical tales, as engraved on the tombs and monuments of pagan kings and chieftains, and from these tales it would appear that they contained simply the names of the persons interred. Thus in the story in *Leabhar na h-Uidhri*, about the identifying of the grave of King Fothadh Airgtheach, in the third century, it is stated that his headstone exhibited, in Ogham characters, the inscription:

FOTHAD AIRCTHECH IND SO,

"Fothadh Airgthech here."

Also in a very ancient poem, beginning Ogum illia, lia uar leact, "Ogum on the stone, the stone over the monument," preserved in the *Book of Leinster*, p. 28, *b*, a stone placed over a monument, with an Ogham inscription, situated on the site of a battle fought in the third century, is thus alluded to:

In t-ogum út ṡíl ir in cloiċ,
Imma torcṙatar mór;
Dammaṙeo Fino ṡictib ṡlono,

[p]Antiquities of Ireland, 2nd edit., pp. 330,331.

Cıan bad ċuman ın Ogom.

"That Ogum which is on the stone,
Around which many were slain;
If Finn of many battles lived,
Long would the Ogum be remembered."

Again, in the tale of Deirdre, published in the Transactions of the Gaelic Society of Dublin, pp. 127, 128, the sepulchral monument of Naisi and Deirdre is thus spoken of:

Do tógḃaḋ a lıag ór a leċt, do ꝼcrıḃaḋ a n-anmanna Ogaım, acaꝼ do ꝼenaḋ a ccluıṫċe caeınte.

"Their stone was raised over their monument, their Ogham names were written, and their ceremony of lamentation was performed."

It would be easy to multiply similar references to pagan monuments inscribed with Ogham characters, but as we have no manuscripts of pagan antiquity, the real proof of the facts above stated must be derived from the monuments themselves; and it is to be hoped that our antiquaries, in examining the ancient Irish sites of pagan battles, carns, sepulchral chambers, and cromlechs, will have a close look out for Ogham inscriptions. It is highly probable that such inscriptions were generally engraved on that part of the stone which was concealed by the earth, in order to prevent the air from wearing the surface of the stone. This, at least, appears to have been the case with the monument of Fothadh Airgthech above alluded to; but from other references it seems that the Ogham inscription was cut on the flag stone with which the monument was covered over head[q] but whether on its upper or under surface, or on its external edges, we cannot determine. Ledwich, in his strictures upon O'Flanagan's paper on the Ogham inscription on the Callan mountain, in the county of Clare, asserts that the stone could not have retained the inscription from the remote period to which O'Flanagan ascribed it, and writes as follows:

"Can it be imagined, that the Callan inscription has stood almost 1500 years in a naked and wild situation, uninjured by the tooth of time, and all the vicissitudes of a variable climate? That the great Atlantic ocean, and its briny atmosphere, have had no influence on this rock, and so far from pulverizing its surface, have rendered it unfit for vegetation? These are wonderful things! Perhaps the venerable Druid who performed the funeral rites to the manes of Conal Colgach (and who has not heard of Conal Colgach?) not only pronounced the 'sit terra levis', but washed the stone with a magic composition of Miseltoe,

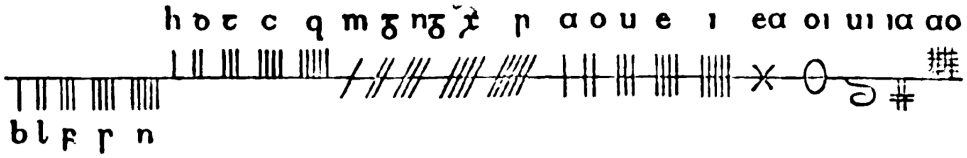
[q]The South Munster Society of Antiquaries have made a considerable collection of Ogham inscriptions, and Mr. Windele of Cork, a zealous advocate for the civilization of the pagan Irish, intends to write a paper on the subject, in which he will point out the situation and nature of the monuments on which they are found.

Semolus, and Selago, and in a fine prophetic phrenzy, predicted the amazing discoveries of Irish Antiquaries in the 18th century[r]."

It is, however, stated by some that this stone had lain buried beneath the earth for ages, while others asserted with confidence that the inscription was forged by Mr. John Lloyd, a Munster Irish poet of the last century, who was the first to notice it himself, in his *Short Description of the County of Clare*, as the monument of Conan, one of Finn Mac Cumhaill's followers! O'Flanagan, without acknowledging that it had been ever deciphered before, actually forges an Irish quatrain, which he cites as a part of the poem called the *Battle of Gabhra*, to prove that Conan was buried on the Callan mountain, whither he had repaired, after the battle of Gabhra, to worship the sun!

The Ogham inscriptions at Dunloe, and elsewhere in Kerry, are, however, of a more authentic character than that on the Callan mountain, but the clue to their interpretation has not yet been discovered; and it would be rash in the extreme to assume without positive proof that they are all pagan, as several of the stones, on which they are inscribed, exhibit crosses, and are clearly Christian monuments.

There are various kinds of Ogham given in the tract in the *Book of Ballymote* already referred to, but a complete discussion of the subject would occupy too much space, and it must therefore suffice to give here the most common form, called the Ogham Craobh, or Virgular Ogham, which is as follows:



Here it is to be noted that the diphthongs beginning with e, as eᴀ, ei, eo, eoi, are all distinguished by a cross (×) intersected by the stem line. The diphthong oi is marked by a circle bisected by the line. The diphthongs and triphthongs beginning with u, as uᴀ, ui, uui, are all marked by a curve TODO below the line. All the diphthongs and triphthongs beginning with i, as iᴀ, io, iu, iui, are denoted by two strokes drawn below the line, with two others intersecting them at right angles. All the diphthongs beginning with ᴀ, as ᴀo, ᴀe, ᴀi, are marked by four parallel strokes intersected at right angles by four others placed above the line. The letter *z* (*ts* or *dz*) which has been decidedly borrowed from the Roman alphabet is represented by a curve of this form TODO ("representans inuolutam Draconis caudam") intersected by the stem line, thus, TODO. A short line drawn parallel to the stem line TODO represents the consonant p; and *q*, which was unquestionably borrowed from the Roman alphabet, and used by the Irish to stand for cu, is indicated by five strokes drawn perpendicular to the stem line.—See O'Molloy's *Grammatica Latino-Hibernica*, pp. 135–142.

[r] *Antiquities of Ireland*, 2nd edit., p. 341

In a MS. in the British Museum (Clarendon 15), various Oghams are described, such as Dinn-Ogham, in which the name of the letters are borrowed from those of hills ; En-Ogham, in which they are borrowed from those of birds; Dath-Ogham, from colours; Cell-Ogham, from churches, &c.; but these are evidently contrivances of later ages.

The ancient Irish also used an obscure mode of speaking, which was likewise called Ogham, and is thus described by O'Molloy: "Obscurum loquendi modum, vulgò Ogham, Antiquarijs Hiberniæsatis notum, quo nimirum loquebantur syllabizando voculas appellationibus litterarum, dipthongorum, et tripthongorum ipsis dumtaxat notis[s]". To this mode of speaking distinct reference is made in the following entry in the *Annals of Clonmacnoise*, as translated by Connell Mageoghegan, in the year 1627:

"A.D. 1328. Morish O'Gibelan, master of art, one exceeding well learned in the new and old laws, civille and cannon, a cunning and skillfull philosopher, an excellent poet in Irish, an eloquent and exact *speaker of the speech, which in Irish is called Ogham* and one that was well seen in many other good sciences: he was a cannon and singer at Twayme, Olfyn, Aghaconary, Killalye, Enaghdown, and Clonfert; he was official and common judge of these dioceses; ended his life this year."

But if the Irish are obliged to resign all claims to letters in the time of paganism, they can still historically boast of having writers among them before the general establishment of Christianity in the fifth century; for we must infer, from the oldest lives of St. Patrick, that there were several christian bishops in Ireland on Patrick's arrival; and we learn from St. Chrysostom, in his *Demonstratio quod Christus sit Deus*, written in the year 387, that the "British Islands, situated outside the Mediterranean sea, and in the very ocean itself, had felt the power of the divine word, churches having been founded there, and altars erected[t]".

But the most curious information respecting the literate character of Ireland before St. Patrick's time, is derived from the accounts of Celestius, who was certainly an Irishman, and the favourite disciple of the heresiarch Pelagius. St. Jerome, alluding to a criticism of Celestius upon his Commentaries on the Epistle of St. Paul to the Ephesians, thus vents his rage against this bold heretic:

"Nuper indoctus calumniator erupit, qui Commentarios meos in epistolam Pauli ad Ephesios reprehendendos putat. Nee intelligit, nimia stertens vecordia, leges Commentariorum, &c.,..... nec recordatur stolidissimus, et Scotorum pultibus prægravatus, nos in ipso dixisse opere: non damno digamos, imo nec trigamos, et si fieri potest octogamos: plus aliquid inferam, etiam scortatorem recipio pœnitentem[u]."

And again, in the *proemium* to his third book on Jeremiah, St. Jerome thus more distinctly mentions the native country of Celestius: "Hie tacet, alibi criminatur; mittit in universum orbem epistolas biblicas, priùs auriferas, nunc maledicas: et patientiam nostram,

[s]Gramatica, p. 133

[t]S. Chysostom, Opp. tom. i. 575, B, Ed. Bened. Καὶγὰρ αἱ Βρετανικαὶ νῆσοι, αἱ τῆς θαλάττης ἐκτὸς κείμεναι ταύτης, καὶ ἐν αὐτῷ οὖσαι τῷ ὠκεανῷ, τῆς δυνάμεως τοῦ ῥήματος ἥσθοντο· καὶ γὰρ κἀκεῖ Ἐκκλησίαι καὶ θυσιαστήρια πεπήγασιν.

[u]Hieron. Prolog. in lib. i. in Hieremiam. Opp. ed. Vallarsii, tom. iv.

de Christi humilitate venientem, malæconscientiæsignum interpretatur. Ipseque mutus latrat per Alpinum [al. *Albinum*] canem grandem et corpulentum, et qui calcibus magis possit sævire, quàm dentibus. Habet enim progeniem Scoticægentis, de Britannorum viciniâ: qui, juxta fabulas Pöetarum, instar Cerberi spirituali percutiendus est clavâ, ut æterno, cum suo magistro Plutone, silentio conticescat[v]."

We learn, however, from Gennadius (who flourished A.D. 495), that before Celestius was imbued with the heresy of Pelagius, he had written from his monastery to his parents three epistles, in the form of little books, containing instructions necessary for all desirous of serving God, and no trace of the heresy which he afterwards broached. The words of Gennadius are as follows:

"Celestius antequàm Pelagianum dogma incurreret, imò adhuc adolescens, scripsit ad parentes suos de monasterio Epistolas in modum libellorum tres, omnibus Deum desiderantibus necessarias. Moralis siquidem in eis dictio nil vitii postmodum proditi, sed totum ad virtutis incitamentum tenuit[w]."

It is conjectured[x] that these letters were written by Celestius from the monastery of St. Martin of Tours, in the year 369. But be this as it may, if Celestius, while a youth, wrote epistles from a foreign monastery to his parents in Scotia, in the neighbourhood of Britain, we must conclude that his parents could read them, and that letters were known in Ireland, then called Scotia, at least to some persons, at the close of the fourth century. For further historical reference to Celestius, and his master Pelagius, the reader is referred to Ussher's *Primordia*, p. 205, *et sequent*., and O' Conor's *Rerum Hibernicarum Scriptores, Prolegomena*, p. lxxxiii.

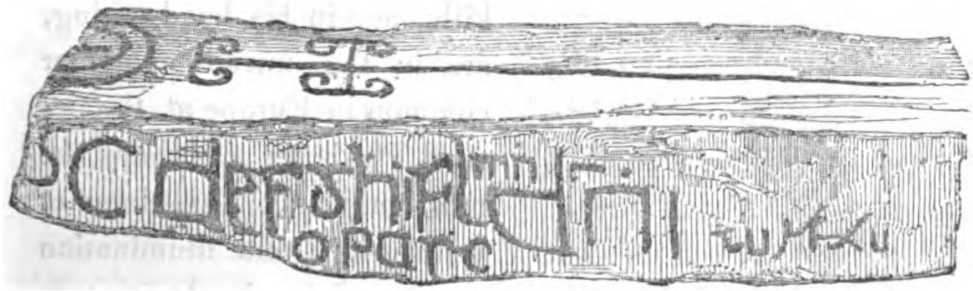
There are also inscriptions still extant to which we may appeal in proof of the early use of letters in Ireland. The following, which is of undoubted antiquity, is a copy of the Roman alphabet, inscribed on a stone at Kilmalkedar, in the west of the county of Kerry. An accurate representation of this inscription is given by Mr. Petrie, in his *Essay on the Ecclesiastical Architecture and Round Towers of Ireland*[y], and is inserted here by permission of the author.

[v]Prolog. i. lib. iii. in Hieremiam. Some, however, think that the heretic Pelagius is here alluded to. See Vallarsius, not. in loc. Opp. S. Hieron. tom. iv. who confounds, both here and in his note on the passage last quoted, the *Scotia* of St. Jerome with the modern Scotland: not knowing that Ireland was the only country called Scotia in St. Jerome's time.

[w]Gennadius de Script. Eccl. c. 44 (inter Opp. B. Hieron. Ed. Vallarsii, tom. ii.)

[x]Moore's *History of Ireland*, vol. i. p. 208.

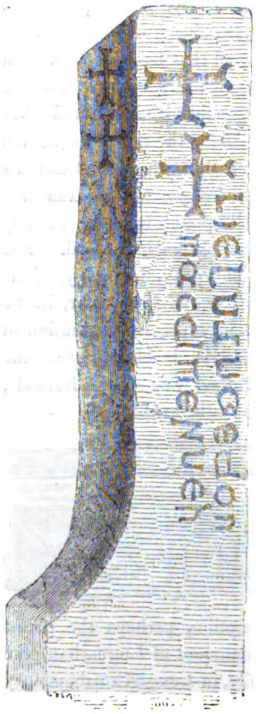
[y]Transactions of the Royal Irish Academy, vol. xx. p. 133



But there is a still older inscription, perhaps the oldest extant, which remains on the monument of Lugnathan, the nephew of St. Patrick, at Inchaguile, in Lough Corrib, county of Galway: of this a fac-simile is also given in Mr. Petrie's work, p. 164, and is here inserted. It contains the following words, in the Roman characters of the fifth century:

LIE LUGNAEDON MACC LIMENUEH.

"The Stone of Lugnaedon Son of Limenueh"



The oldest Irish manuscript extant in Ireland is the Book of Armagh, now in the possession of the Rev. Mr. Brownlow. It contains a copy of the Gospels, and some very old *Lives of St. Patrick*; the characters are clearly a slight modification of the Roman alphabet, with a few Greek characters in the titles of the Gospels.

The Books of Durrow and Kells, in the Library of Trinity College, Dublin, said to be coeval with St. Columbkille, and in his handwriting, are in the uncial character common in Europe at the period. The latter is, perhaps, the most magnificent specimen of penmanship and illumination now remaining in the western world.

There is another manuscript of great age preserved in the Library of Trinity College, Dublin, called *Liber Hymnorum* containing several ancient hymns in Latin and Irish, of which work there is another copy in the College of St. Isidore at Rome. This, though evidently not so ancient, nor so exquisitely beautiful, as those already mentioned, is in the same character, and sufficiently proves that the Irish letters are immediately derived from the Roman alphabet. Ussher, in a letter to Vossius, expressed his opinion that this manuscript was then a thousand years old, but I think he increased its age by a century or two.

The manuscript of the Psalter, preserved in the Cathach, or Caah, a beautiful reliquary, now the property of Sir Richard O'Donnell, is also very probably coeval with St. Columba, if indeed it be not in his handwriting. This most curious box and reliquary has been deposited, by the public spirit and good taste of its owner, in the Museum of the Royal Irish Academy.

A fac-simile of an Irish passage in a manuscript at Cambray, has been recently published by Charles Purten Cooper, Esq., from which it would appear that the manuscript is probably of the eighth century. The character looks as old as that of any manuscript we have in Ireland, and differs from any of them that I have ever seen, in the form of the letter ꞃ , which is thus (TODO). Pertz, who has read the passage tolerably well, considering that he does not understand a word of the language, ascribes this manuscript to the ninth century.

The next oldest Irish manuscript remaining in Ireland is probably the Book of Leinster, preserved in the Library of Trinity College, Dublin (H. 2. 18.); and next in order of time I would rank *Leabhar na h-Uidhri*, in the Library of the Royal Irish Academy, which was transcribed by Maelmuire Mac Cuinn na m-bocht, at Clonmacnoise, in the twelfth century. Next may be classed the *Leabhar Breac* of the Mac Egans, the Books of Lecan and Ballymote, and a host of others compiled from more original manuscripts, in the fifteenth century. The characters in these are of a more angular form than those in the more ancient manuscripts[z].

Specimens of alphabets from the most important of these ancient manuscripts, forming a series, nearly complete, from the sixth to the seventeenth century, will be found in the

[z]Mons. Adolphe Pictet of Geneva, in a letter addressed to the late Edward O'Reilly, dated 24th June, 1835, seems to incline to the opinion that we had no written documents in Ireland before the fourth or fifth century, or at least that this is the most remote period to which written documents can be traced. The querics which this learned philologer proposes in this letter are very curious, and hsould not be omitted here:
"1º. La seconde edition de votre dictionnaire, a t-elle paru, ou doit elle biéntôt paroitre ?
2º. Existe-t-il quelque bon dictionnaire anglias-irlandias ?
3º. A-t-on publié, depuuis O'Conor, ou doit-on publier prochainement, quelques textes anciens, soit poetiques, soit historiques, soit philologiques ? Comment l'académie royale d'Irlande n'encourage-t-elle pas la publication des textes anciens des Brehon laws, de poëmes encore existans de Cenfaolad, de Eochoid, de Tanaide, de Maelmuire, etc. du glossaire de Cormac de l'uraicheapt de Fortchern, etc. ?
4º. N'a-t-on retrouvé aucun fragment de traduction de la Bible en ancien irlandias, dont ou puisse fixer la date avec quelque certitude ? par ancien irlandais j'entends la langue telle qu'elle existoit anterieurement au dixième siécle et depuis le 4ieme ou 5ieme époque la plus reculée, je crois a laquelle remontent les documens écrits.
5º. Connoissez-vous quelque ouvrage de topographie sur l'Irelande ancienne ou moderne, qui renferme d'une manière exacte et un peu compléte les noms de lieux, fleuves, lacs, montagnes, provinces, tribes, etc. avec l'orthographie irlandaise ?
"Voila, monsieur, bien des questions. Je m'excuse encore de mon indiscretion en prenant la liberté de vous les adresser: l'interet de la science plaidera pour moi. Si vous êtes assez bon pour voulouir bien m'aider de vos lumières j'espere que mes travaux ne seront pas inutiles à la cause trop méconnue des etudes celtiques, et réveilleront sur le continent un interet nouveau pour les restes vénérables de la litterature du plus ancienne peuple de l'Europe."

annexed plates. They have been drawn, from the original manuscripts, by George Du Noyer, Esq., one of the Fellows of the College of St. Columba.

0.2 Of the Writers on Irish Grammar

Having now noticed the bardic accounts of the antiquity of letters among the Irish, and the authorities which prove the existence of learning in Ireland before St. Patrick, we shall next give some account of the labours of those who have written on Irish grammar. The first work of this kind mentioned by the Irish writers is *Uraicecht na n-Eiges*, or Precepts of the Poets. This treatise is attributed to Forchern, or Ferceirtne, the son of Deaghaidh, from whom the Deagads, or Clanna Deaghaidh, of Munster, are descended. It is said to have been written at Emania, the royal palace of Ulster, in the first century, but was afterwards interpolated and enlarged at Derryloran, in Tyrone, about the year 628, by Cennfaeladh, the son of Ailill. Copies of this work, as remodelled by Cennfaeladh, are preserved in the Books of Lecan and Ballymote, in the Library of the Royal Irish Academy, and a more ancient one, on vellum, in the British Museum, which the Author has recently perused. This work contains rules for poetical compositions, and is rather a prosody than a regular grammar. In a paper manuscript, in the Library of Trinity College, Dublin (H. 1. 15), is a larger work, called *Uraiceacht* which gives genders and inflections of nouns, and various orthographical and etymological rules; but this work is a compilation of comparatively modern times.

There are several short treatises on Irish grammar, in manuscript, by various writers in the seventeenth century, in the Library of Trinity College, and one, by O'Mulconry, in that of St. Sepulchre's, Dublin; and we learn from the monument of Sir Mathew De Renzi, at Athlone, who died in 1635, that he composed a *grammar*, *dictionary*, and *chronicle*, in the Irish tongue.

The first Irish book ever printed, with instructions for reading Irish, was John Kearney's "*Alphabeticum et Ratio legendi Hibernicam, et Catechismus in eadem Lingua*, 1571, 8vo." The only known copy of this curious and rare book is preserved in the Bodleian Library, Oxford.

The first printed Irish grammar is that of the Rev. Francis O'Molloy, written in Latin, and entitled "Grammatica Latino-Hibernica, nunc compendiata,—Authore Rev. P. Fr. Francisco O'Molloy, Ord. Min. Strict. Observantiæ, in Collegio S. Isidori S. Theol. Professore Primario, Lectore Jubilato, et Prouinciæ Hiberniæ in Curia Romana Agente Generali. Romæ, Typographia S. Cong, de Propag. Fide 1677." It contains 286 pages, 12mo., and is divided into twenty-five chapters, of which the first nine treat of the letters; the tenth, eleventh, and twelfth, of etymology, of which he treats but very slightly; the thirteenth

See Statute of Kilkenny, edited by Mr. Hardiman for the Irish Archæological Society, p. 12, note g.

The Catechism is a Translation into Irish of the Catechism of the England, which is followed by some Prayers and Collects from the Book of Common Prayer.

chapter is on the oghams and contractions; and the remaining twelve, of the ancient Irish prosody, into which he enters very copiously.

The next grammar of Irish which issued from the press was written by the celebrated antiquary Lhwyd. It was published in his *Archæologia Britannica*, and prefixed to his Irish-English Dictionary, Oxford, 1707. This work was extracted from O'Molloy's, and from another work on Irish grammar, in manuscript, written by an anonymous author at Louvain, in 1669. It is somewhat more copious than O'Molloy's in the etymology, but is still very imperfect. He omits the defective or irregular verbs altogether, observing that they are very numerous, and that in conjugating them, "the common use and practice of the province, &c., is the only pattern." From the preface to his Dictionary, written in Irish, it appears that this great philologer knew almost nothing of the idioms of the Irish language, for he uses the English collocation in most of his sentences, which gives his Irish composition a strange, if not ridiculous, appearance.

The next Irish grammar that made its appearance after Lhwyd's, was written by Hugh Boy Mac Curtin, a native of the parish of Kilcorney, near Corofin, in the county of Clare. It is entitled "The Elements of the Irish Language, grammatically explained in English, in fourteen chapters: small 8vo. Lovain, 1728." It was reprinted with his English-Irish Dictionary, at Paris, in 1732. This work is much more copious that its predecessors, particularly in the etymology and syntax, on which the author has every claim to originality. Of the irregular verbs he says, that they are very numerous, and that in the forming thereof, the common use or practice of the kingdom, or the distinct dialects of each province, is the only guide and rule. He omits prosody altogether.

In 1742, Donlevy published, at Paris, his Irish-English Catechism, to which he appended instructions for reading the Irish language, entitled "The Elements of the Irish Language." This treats of orthography only, but it is by far the best treatise on the subject that had till then appeared. At the end, he says: "Such as desire to get more Insight into the *Grammar-Rules* of this *Language* may have recourse to the *laborious* M. Hugh Mac Curtin's *Irish Grammar*. The chief Difficulty of reading, or speaking *Irish*, consists in pronouncing ꝺh, ꞡh, and some Diphthongs and Triphthongs rightly; but this is easily overcome by Practice, or a little instruction by the Ear; whereby the Pronunciation of the *Language* will become agreeable, there being much Use made of *Vowels*, and little of *Consonants*, in it."

No other Irish Grammar appeared after this till the year 1773, when Vallancey published his, in quarto, with a preface, which tended to call attention to a subject then but little appreciated. Of this work he brought out an improved edition, in octavo, in 1782, with an "Essay on the Celtic language, shewing the importance of the Iberno-Celtic or Irish dialect to students in history, antiquity, and the Greek and Roman classics."

This work is compiled from those already mentioned, and from O'Brien's remarks on the letters throughout his Irish-English Dictionary. The author has treated of the irregular verbs more copiously and satisfactorily than any of his predecessors, and assures

the learner that "they are not so numerous or more difficult than those of Latin, French, or English." His syntax, which is briefly dismissed in twelve rules, is much inferior to that of his predecessor Mac Curtin. On the whole, this work shews considerable research, and curious learning; but it is more theoretical than practical, and better adapted to assist the comparative etymologist than the mere Irish student. It is by far the most valuable and correct of Vallancey's writings, and is doubtlessly the joint production of the avowed author and several native Irish scholars.

Shortly after Vallancey's, appeared Shaw's Gælic Grammar, Edinburgh, 1778; but this is confined to the Erse or Gælic of Scotland, and its merits are very questionable. In 1801 appeared the first edition of a Gælic Grammar, by Alexander Stewart, Minister of the Gospel at Moulin. Of this an improved edition was brought out in 1812, which is undoubtedly the ablest work on Gælic grammar that ever appeared.

In 1808 was published, in Dublin, an Irish Grammar, in octavo, entitled Uṁaiceċt na Ḋaeöilge, "A Grammar of the Irish Language," under the fictitious signature of *E. O'C*, which, in the Prospectus, is given in full as Edmund O'Connell; but the author, as many living witnesses can attest, was William Halliday, Esq., a solicitor in Dublin, who studied Irish as a dead language, and who died before he reached his twenty-fifth year, having produced this grammar in his nineteenth year. He derived much information from the first edition of Stewart's Gælic Grammar, and from Messrs. Wolfe, O'Connell, and Casey, three Irish scholars, natives of Munster, with the latter of whom he commenced the study of the language in 1805, under the fictitious name of *William O'Hara*. In this work he rejects the modern Irish orthography as corrupt, and strikes out a new mode of classifying the declensions of nouns. His syntax is almost wholly drawn from the works of Mac Curtin and Stewart, particularly the latter, whose arrangement and diction he has closely followed; and indeed he could not have followed a safer model. However, he has pointed out some errors in the first edition of Stewart's Gælic Grammar, which Stewart himself thankfully acknowledges and corrects in the second edition of his work, published in 1812. Haliday

The only other production given to the world by Vallancey which shews much ability, is the Law of Tanistry exemplified by the Pedigree of O'Brien; but this work was written not by Vallancey, but by the Right Rev. John O'Brien, Roman Catholic Bishop of Cloyne, as appears from a letter in the hand-writing of the Chevalier Thomas O'Gorman, in the possession of Terence O'Brien, Esq., of Glencolumbkille, in the county of Clare. O'Gorman, in referring to a genealogical extract from Vallancey's Collectanea, says: "The above genealogy is extracted from the History of the House of O'Brien, *written by the late Doctor John O'Brien, titular Bishop of Cloyne*, and published in the year 1774, by Col. Vallancey."

The Rev. Mr. Stewart in te Introduction to the 2nd edition of his Gælic Grammar, has the following reference to his work: "I know but one publication professedly of Gaelic Grammar, written by a Scotsman (Analysis of the Gælic Language; by William Saw, A. M.); but I have consulted it also, but in this quarter I have no obligations to acknowledge." p. xiii.

Stewart writes in the Introduction: "The Irish dialect of the Gaelic is the nearest cognate of the Scottish Gaelic. An intimate acquaintance with its vocables and structure, both ancient and modern, would have been of considerable use. This I cannot pretend to have acquired. I have

gives the ancient Irish prosody, but merely as shortened from O'Molloy, with, here and there, a few remarks of his own. This work, however, considering the early age and disadvantages of its author, must be regarded as one of much merit; it bears the stamp of taste, genius, and originality, not at all observable in the works of his predecessors.

In the same year (1808) was published, in Dublin, "An Introduction to the Irish Language," by the Rev. William Neilson, D. D., 8vo. This grammar is the joint production of Dr. Meilson and Mr. Patrick Lynch, a native of the parish of Inch, near Castlewellan, in the county of Down. Mr. Lynch had a good practical knowledge of the dialect of Irish spoken in the east of Ulster, but was a rude scholar. The orthography, however, and grammatical rules, are adapted to this dialect, and not to the general language. The arrangement of the work is excellent, but it is to be regretted that the examples given to illustrate the rules are, for the most part, provincial and barbaric.

In 1808 the Gælic Society of Dublin published, in their Transactions, "Observations on the Gaelic Language, by R. Mac Elligott." The same writer also compiled an Irish Grammar, which is stille extant in manuscript, in the possession of his daughter, Mrs. Ryding of Limerick, but was never printed. He was a native of the county of Kerry, a region in which they studied classics "even to a fault," in his time, and was for many years a classical teacher in the city of Limerick, where he created a high taste for classical and polite literature.

The next year (1809) ushered into light "A Practical Grammar of the Irish Language,"

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not failed, however, to consult and derive some advantage from such Irish philologists as were accessible to me; particularly O'Molloy, O'Brien, Vallancey, and Lhwyd. To these very respectable names, I have to add that of the Rev. Dr. Neilson, author of 'An Introduction to the Irish Language,' Dublin, 1808; and E. O'C., author of a 'Grammar of the Gælic Language,' Dublin, 1808; to the latter of whom I am indebted for some good-humoured strictures, and some flattering compliments, which, however umerited, it were unhandsome not to acknolwedge." p. xiii.

Mr. Patrick Lynch, the author of the Life of St. Patrick, has the following note in an advertisement of his works appended to his *Introduction to the Knowledge of the Irish Language:* "N.B. The new translation of the first volume of Keating's History" [of Ireland] "though originally published in Mr. Lynch's name, was begun and actually completed by the late William Halliday, Esq., whose much lamented death at the premature age of 24, is a cause of heart-felt regret, not only to the Gaelic Society, of which he was an active member, but to the lovers of Irish literature in general."

For some account of the literary qualifications of Mr. Mac Elligott, the reader is referred to a pamphlet published in London, in 1844, by his pupil, the Rev. Jonathon Furlong, in reply to certain observations by Dr. D. Griffin, of Limerick, in the life of Gerald Griffin, the celebrated novelist. We learn from O'Flanagan that Mr. Mac Elligott had got some valuable Irish manuscripts in his possession in 1808. In enumerating the collections of Irish manuscripts known to him, O'Flanagan writes: "The Cehvalier O'Gorman, now living in the county of Clare, has a rare collection of annals, and other inestimable monuments. The books of Lecan and Ballymote, and the Leꞝan bꞇec, or 'speckled book,' of Mac Egan are in the archives of the Royal Irish Academy; and there are besides several valuable tracts in private hands throughout the island, of which those in the posessoin of the learned M'Elligott, of Limerick, are not the least worthy of estimation."—*Transactions of the Gælic Society of Dublin,* p. 235.

by the Rev. Paul O'Brien. This is, perhaps, the worst attempt hitherto made to explain the principles of this language. The author was a native of Meath, and a man of some learning; but the visionary character of his mind disqualified him for the important task of writing a grammar of an ancient and neglected language. He does not appear to have had any acquaintance with Irish history or topography, or with any of the correct ancient Irish manuscripts. There are many specimens of his poetry in the native Irish preserved, but they exhibit no merit, except the mere power of stringing together long compound words in jingling rhyme, without poetic genius, or strength of thought. His Irish Grammar is the production of his old age; and the late Mr. James Scurry says, in his Review of Irish Grammars and Dictionaries, published in the fifteenth volume of the Transactions of the Royal Irish Academy, that "it is not to be taken as a fair specimen of the vigour of his intellect, or the extent of his learning."

In 1813 Mr. John O'Connell, of the parish of Tuath na Droman, near Caherciveen, in Kerry, published at Cork an Irish translation of F. Paul Segnary's "True Wisdom," to which he prefixed short "Instructions for reading Irish," which are very correct. This translation is a curious specimen of the dialect of the Irish spoken in Kerry.

In 1815 was published, in Dublin, a small grammatical tract, entitled "*Foroidcas Ghnath-Ghaoidheilge na h-Eireand*, An Introduction to the Knowledge of the Irish Language as now spoken," by Patrick Lynch, Secretary to the Gaelic Society of Dublin. This little work contains some very valuable remarks on the pronunciation and genius of the Irish Language, although it cannot be considered as entitled to the name of a grammar. Mr. Lynch was a native of the county of Limerick; he kept a classical school at Carrick-on-Suir in 1800, and afterwards removed to Dublin, where, for many years, he taught the classical languages, French and Hebrew. He wrote small works on grammar, chronology, astronomy, geography, and history; but the most celebrated of his works is his "Proofs of the Existence of St. Patrick," written chiefly to refute Ledwich's assertions. This work was published in Dublin, in 1810, and contains short "Directions for reading Irish." Mr. Lynch was of the Milesian Irish race (and wrote his name Patruic O'Loingsigh), and not of the Galway tribe of that name.

In 1817 appeared "A Compendious Irish Grammar," by Edward O'Reilly, annexed to his Irish-English Dictionary. This is chiefly compiled from the Rev. Paul O'Brien's Grammar, and partakes of all its faults and defects. His system of making the initials of nouns the foundation of the declensions, in imitation of O'Brien, is quite absurd, as the tables of terminational changes, given in both grammars, sufficiently shew. The author was a man of strong mind, good memory, and studious habits, but had little or no acquaintance with the classical languages, or with any, except English. He learned Irish as a dead language, and had not commenced the study of it till he was more than thirty years of age; but by laudable perseverence, and strong powers of intellect, he acquired a considerable knowledge of the ancient Irish language and history.

In 1820 was published, at Waterford, an Irish translation of John Baptista Manni's

"Four Maxims of Christian Philosophy," by Mr. James Scurry, of Knockhouse, in the barony of Iverk, and county of Kilkenny. To this is prefixed "An Introduction to the Irish Language, containing a comprehensive Exemplification of all the alphabetical Sounds, and their corresponding English Sounds, as a further Illustration of them, as far as could be effected by the Substitution of English characters."

This treatise is valuable, as giving the pronunciation which prevails in the diocese of Ossory, with which the writer was most intimately acquainted.

In 1828 Mr. Scurry published, in the fifteenth volume of the Transactions of the Royal Irish Academy, "Remarks on the Irish Language, with a Review of its Grammars, Glossaries, Vocabularies, and Dictionaries; to which is added a Model of a comprehensive Irish Dictionary." In this paper, p. 55, the author says, "that he had prepared for press a grammar, both theoretical and practical, formed on the genius of the language, the result of many years' consideration of the subject, which he had been deterred from publishing, from the little encouragement works of that nature had met with from the public." Mr. Scurry was a respectable farmer, and though his education was imperfect, he was a man of so vigorous a mind that he acquired an extensive knowledge of philology and general literature. He died in Dublin in 1828, and his body was buried in the church of Kilpecan, near the village of Mullinavat, in the county Kilkenny, where it lies without a monument to exhibit even his name.

Various other compilations, and abstracts from these grammars, have since been published; but the limits of this preface would not permit a particular description of them. The largest work of this kind was published in Dublin, in 1841, and compiled for the Synod of Ulster, by S. O'M. Dr. Mason, Librarian of the King's Inns, Dublin, also compiled an Irish Grammar; but it is to be regretted that he has adopted the system of O'Brien and O'Reilly to a considerable extent. The Rev. Mr. Nangle, of Achill, has also brought out a second edition of Neilson's Irish Grammar, with some judicious corrections. And Mr. Owen Connellan, who was employed for many years in the Royal Irish Academy, to transcribe the Books of Lecan and Ballymote, for the Royal Library, has recently published a small work on Irish Grammar, with examples from Irish MSS., not to be found in any of the works of his predecessors. He also gives the pronunciation which prevails in the northern part of Connaught, which will be found very useful, in preserving for posterity the local peculiarities of the Connacian dialect.

Some works have also been written on the grammar of the Gaelic of Scotland, by Armstrong and Munroe; but they contain nothing original, the Rev. Alexander Stewart having exhausted the subject, in his very excellent Gaelic Grammar, published in 1812.

The Author of these pages became acquainted with Mr. Scurry in Dublin, in the year 1826, and found that, although he had but slight acquaintance with Latin or Greek, he had still a sound knowledge of philosophical grammar. He was the first that induced the Author to study the grammatical works of Harris, Ward, Horne Tooke, Pickburne, and Fearns, and the antiquarian productions of Baxter, Davies, and Vallancey.